

The Girl from the Poorhouse

The true story of Mary “Marietta” Blackwell, 1877–1938, and of her mother Ann — from a Liverpool steerage deck to the friends who carried her home

Researched and written from original records by Robert Babcock

In memory of his great-great-grandmother

The story Grandma told

For as long as anyone can remember, our family carried a fragment of a story. Grandma Bernadine (Brand) Babcock said that her grandmother — Marietta Blackwell, who married Jacob Brand — had been *an orphan from Ireland*. Nobody knew who her parents were. There was even a whispered rumor, never verified, that they might have been clergy back in Ireland.

Family stories like this usually dissolve when you go looking for paper. This one did the opposite. The first edition of this paper, written in August 2026, recovered the thing the family never had: her mother’s name. In the weeks since, the records have given up far more — the mother’s whole life, from the ship that likely carried her out of Ireland at fifteen, to the Utica household that took her in, to the friends who claimed her body at the end so that she would not lie in a pauper’s grave. The second edition told that story complete, and corrected one detail the first edition got wrong — a correction that made the story better, not worse. The third edition added the part that was still unfolding: the active hunt to trace Ann back to the very parish in Ireland she walked out of — the leads we are following right now, and our best guesses, plainly labeled as guesses, about where she came from. This fourth edition fills in the piece Dad and Aunt Sandi kept coming back to whenever they talked about Marietta — the detail repeated most often, in almost the same words, across two branches of the family who rarely compare notes: that she came west on an *orphan train*. That single word turns out to unlock the very question the earlier

editions left open — how a poorhouse toddler in Utica ended up, a few years later, in the parlor of a German Catholic merchant a thousand miles away — and it is worth telling in full, because almost nobody today knows what an orphan train actually was.

A three-year-old in the poorhouse

The search began with a strange entry in the 1880 federal census. In Rome, Oneida County, New York, the census taker walked through an institution whose name he wrote across the top of the page: *Oneida County Poorhouse*. Among the residents — paupers and invalids born in Ireland, Germany, and England — he recorded a little girl.

1880 UNITED STATES CENSUS · ONEIDA COUNTY POORHOUSE, ROME, N.Y. E.D. 112, p. 61B

NAME *Blackwell, Mary*

AGE 3

CONDITION **“Homeless”**

A three-year-old, marked *homeless*, in a county poorhouse. This was our Marietta — the birth date matches her later records to the day: February 2, 1877, New York. Every document she left behind as an adult — census after census, and finally her death certificate — would say the same thing about her parents: *Unknown*.

But the poorhouse kept its own books. And in those books, we found her mother.

Ann Blackwell of Ireland

New York law required every county poorhouse to keep a standardized record of each inmate. On September 30, 1876 — five months before Mary was born — the keeper of the Oneida County Poor House filled out a form for a new arrival.

NAME	<i>Ann Blackwell</i>
AGE / CONDITION	<i>30 · Single</i>
BIRTH PLACE	Ireland
OCCUPATION	<i>House servant</i>
RELATIVES	<i>None</i>
CAUSE OF DEPENDENCE	<i>"Having young child"</i>

Ann Blackwell was an unmarried Irish immigrant, working as a house servant, alone in America, and four months pregnant. She entered the poorhouse that autumn, and on February 2, 1877, inside its walls, she gave birth to a daughter: Mary. At the bottom of the form, the superintendent added several lines in his own hand:

"This is the second child this woman has had. The first one she swore on a boy by the name of Martin, and he paid... about \$20 in the hands of the County Superintendent, as the child died some time ago. I do not know what can be done about this one, as I understand she can not swear who is its father."

SUPERINTENDENT'S REMARKS, ONEIDA COUNTY POOR HOUSE RECORD, 1876

Those sentences explain a mystery that ran through sixty years of records: Mary's father was never named. They also tell us Ann had already buried a first baby. It is worth reading the last line carefully. Ann knew how to swear paternity — she had done it once, successfully, and the county had collected support money on her behalf. That she "can not swear" the second time may mean she did not know; it may equally mean the father was a man a servant girl could not afford to name. The record permits both readings, and honesty requires us to keep both. Either way, the form preserved what no one else did: that Marietta's mother existed, that she had a name, and that she came from Ireland.

Together, then taken

The first edition of this paper repeated what the census index showed: that three-year-old Mary was enumerated *alone*. That turned out to be an artifact of the database. When we later pulled the original 1880 page and read every handwritten line, the truth was waiting a few entries away, in the same dwelling, on the same sheet of paper:

1880 UNITED STATES CENSUS · THE SAME PAGE		E.D. 112, p. 61B, dw. 90
NAME	<i>Blackwell, Ann · age 32 · born Ireland</i>	
CONDITION	“Destitute”	

Mother and daughter were in the poorhouse together. Mary was never abandoned there. For the first three and a half years of her life, whatever else that grim building was, her mother was in it with her.

What separated them was not a choice but a statute. New York’s *Children’s Law* of 1875 barred children over the age of two from being kept in county poorhouses — a reform meant to save children from growing up in institutions full of the sick and the destitute. In practice it meant the county was required to remove Mary from her mother. Oneida County’s practice, described in the State Board of Charities reports of the period, was to move such children to Utica asylums and “thence place them in families.” Mary was sent to the *House of the Good Shepherd* in Utica — founded in 1872 by the women of Trinity Episcopal Church, and the only institution in Utica that took the youngest children. It was an Episcopal house, but its own reports say it received “many Roman Catholics.” Ann did not give Mary up. The State of New York, with the best of intentions, took her.

What an orphan train was

Ask Dad, or ask Aunt Sandi, and the detail comes back almost word for word. Sandra Walsberg, Grandma Bernadine’s daughter, put it this way in an email in September 2026:

"His mother was an Irish orphan. She and her brother were on an orphan train. She was adopted by a St Louis doctor, was treated very good but worked for them."

SANDRA WALSBURG (AUNT SANDI), EMAIL TO THE FAMILY, SEPTEMBER 2026

Robert's father, Robert S. Babcock, remembered the same word independently. Neither of them had to be told what it meant — it had simply always been part of how the family talked about Marietta. Most people today have never heard of it, so it is worth explaining properly, because it is not folklore. It was one of the largest, longest-running child welfare programs in American history, and it happened to run directly through this family.

Beginning in 1854, a young minister named Charles Loring Brace looked at what New York City was doing with its homeless and orphaned children — warehousing thousands of them in almshouses and juvenile asylums, often alongside adult paupers and the insane — and decided there had to be something better. His new Children's Aid Society began putting groups of children on trains west, to be met at each stop by local committees of farmers and townspeople willing to take one in. Between 1854 and 1929, historians estimate somewhere between 150,000 and 200,000 children rode these trains, to nearly every state in the country. The idea, radical for its time, was that a poor child raised in a working farm family, doing chores and going to the local school, would grow up better than the same child raised inside an institution — and that a rural family, in turn, gained an extra pair of hands. It was rescue and labor at once, and it was administered, on the whole, with genuine and serious intent to do right by the children.

This is precisely the reasoning behind the New York *Children's Law* of 1875 already described above — the same law that took Mary from her mother in the Oneida County Poorhouse. Removing very young children from almshouses and placing them in real families, rather than institutions, was the whole philosophy of the age. Mary's story is not a strange exception to that reform movement. It is the reform movement, working exactly as designed, on one specific little girl.

Which train, and whose family

Charles Loring Brace's Children's Aid Society was the largest such organization, but it was not the only one, and the other two candidates fit Mary's own case far better — because both of them specialized in exactly her situation: a very young, Catholic child, sent specifically to Illinois.

The first is the **New York Foundling Hospital**, opened in 1869 by the Sisters of Charity as a Catholic answer to Brace's largely Protestant program — Catholic leaders worried, not without reason, that Catholic children riding CAS trains were quietly being raised Protestant in their new homes. From 1875 to 1914 the Foundling ran its own placing-out trains, nicknamed "baby trains" because they specialized in infants and toddlers — exactly Mary's age. Its method was distinctive and remarkably organized: a parish priest in the receiving town would vet an applicant family in advance and mail the Sisters a completed application; the Sisters would match a specific child to that specific family *before the child ever boarded the train*; and a small tag, sewn into the child's clothing, carried a number matching a card already in the waiting family's hands. At the station, family and Sister compared cards, and the child went home. The receiving parents signed a three-page indenture agreement on the spot, committing them to specific, spelled-out terms — among them, schooling.

The second candidate is the **New York Juvenile Asylum**, an older reform institution that, starting in 1855 under the Rev. Enoch Kingsbury, built a placement pipeline that ran, in the Asylum's own words, "almost exclusively" to one destination: Illinois. By 1861 the arrangement was formal enough that the Illinois legislature passed a special act defining exactly how these indentures had to work, and the Asylum went on sending children into Illinois for the next forty-one years. Its indentures likewise required the receiving family to provide "schooling, proper clothing, church attendance," along with a payment due to the child at the end of the indenture — \$75 for a girl, at eighteen.

We do not yet know, with documentary certainty, which of these two agencies carried Mary. Both fit strikingly well: a Foundling Hospital baby train would explain why a Catholic institution's toddler ended up with a devout Catholic family; a Juvenile Asylum placement would explain, better than anything else could, why the destination was Illinois specifically, since the Asylum sent its children almost nowhere else. It is entirely possible both institutions touched her case in sequence — the House of the Good Shepherd holding her in Utica immediately after her removal from the poorhouse, and one of these two placing agencies arranging the actual westward journey once a suitable family had

been found. We checked what we could: the New York Juvenile Asylum maintains a partial surviving index of the children it placed, built from its own old ledgers. It lists six Blackwells — Albert, Harold E., Harrold E., James (b. 1912), Robert, and William — and not one of them is a girl, let alone a girl born in 1877. That is a genuine, honest negative: it does not rule out the Asylum, since the surviving list is admittedly incomplete and was compiled from handwriting its own keeper calls hard to read, but it gives us nothing to confirm the Asylum either. The single document that would settle this — Mary's own placement file, wherever it survives — remains lead #5 in the list below, and it is now our best-understood open question in this whole research.

The promise about school

Both agencies' indentures, and in fact virtually every orphan-train indenture on record, made the same promise on paper: the receiving family would send the child to school, typically for a set number of months each year, in exchange for the child's work around the house or farm. Robert's grandmother told him something specific about this, and it deserves to be recorded in her own words as he remembers them: that one of the terms of Marietta's placement was that she would be educated — and that, as the family always understood it, this promise was never really kept.

That is a serious, specific, and checkable claim, and it holds up as one of the best-documented failure points of the entire orphan-train system. Agents for these organizations were supposed to visit and confirm that families were honoring their indentures, but visits were infrequent and enforcement was weak, and the single most commonly broken promise, across the whole movement's history, was exactly this one: families that wanted an extra pair of working hands more than they wanted another child in the schoolhouse. Nothing about the Pfeffer household suggests unkindness — quite the opposite, as the next section shows — but it was also a working merchant's house with fourteen children of its own, a boarder, and, by 1900, an unmarried adult daughter and an adopted daughter both still living at home and both unmarried. It is easy to imagine a busy household finding more use for an extra pair of hands at home than at a desk.

What the record can and cannot tell us: the one census that would have caught her mid-childhood and asked directly whether she was attending school — the 1890 federal census

— was almost entirely destroyed by fire in 1921, and no version of it survives for Monroe County, Illinois. That is a genuine, frustrating gap, not a choice we made. What does survive is the 1900 census, taken when she was twenty-three, which asked three separate questions of every adult: *Can Read. Can Write. Can Speak English.* For “Jennie Pfeffer,” the enumerator wrote **Y, Y, Y** to all three. She was a literate, English-speaking, twenty-three-year-old woman. That does not prove she received the schooling the indenture promised — children of that era very often learned their letters at home, or in a few winter months of informal instruction, without ever completing anything like a full course of schooling — but it does tell us the promise was not *entirely* broken. The honest picture, holding Grandma’s memory and this one document together, is of a family that gave Marietta enough education to read and write and get by in the world, and probably a good deal less than the indenture, on paper, said she was owed.

The doctor, the brother, and the theater

Aunt Sandi believed Marietta’s adoptive father himself — the man we know from the records as John A. Pfeffer — was “a St. Louis doctor.” Every document we have found agrees on who he was and disagrees on both particulars: Pfeffer ran a substantial general store in Columbia, Illinois, not a medical practice, and Columbia sits just across the Mississippi from St. Louis rather than in it. We do not think this is a contradiction worth throwing out the rest of the story over — if anything, it confirms how the story traveled. John A. Pfeffer raised fourteen children of his own in a large house and was, by the standards of a small Illinois farm town, one of its more prosperous and prominent men. Four generations later, “a prominent, well-off man near St. Louis who took in an orphan girl” is exactly the kind of detail that settles into family memory as “a St. Louis doctor” — the profession changes, the man does not.

The “brother” in Sandi’s account — “she and her brother were on an orphan train” — matches something this paper already flagged as an open lead before this edition was written: no second Blackwell child has yet turned up in the Oneida County records, but siblings were, as a matter of routine practice on these trains, very often separated and placed with different families in different towns, sometimes hundreds of miles apart, precisely because so few individual households were willing or able to take two children at once. If Mary did have a brother who rode west with her, an agency ledger somewhere

may show him placed at an entirely different stop — which would neatly explain why he never appears in any Illinois record connected to the Pfeffers, and why the family lost track of him for good.

The most vivid piece of testimony is the one Sandi calls the theater story:

“Grandpa Brand’s father was a contractor, built a theater. Grandpa took his mother to that theater and there was a man on stage telling the story about the orphan train. He was looking for his sister who got off in St Louis. Grandpa’s mother sat there and did not acknowledge that she was his sister.”

SANDRA WALSBURG (AUNT SANDI), EMAIL TO THE FAMILY, SEPTEMBER 2026

This fits a real and well-documented practice from later in the orphan-train era: as riders grew into adulthood, a number of them took to the lecture circuit, touring town halls, churches, and theaters to tell their own story — and more than a few used the stage specifically to appeal, in public, for a lost brother or sister to come forward. It was a genuine, if unusual, feature of American public life in the early twentieth century, and the National Orphan Train Complex in Concordia, Kansas, today preserves many first-person accounts of exactly this kind of reunion search. We have not yet located a specific newspaper notice for a lecture in or near Columbia or East St. Louis, nor confirmed which theater “Grandpa Brand’s father” — Joseph Brand, a Columbia house carpenter, not a large-scale contractor so far as any record shows — might have helped build. Both are open leads rather than closed ones. But the shape of the story is exactly right for its era, and if Marietta really did sit in an audience and let a stranger’s public search for his lost sister pass without a word, it says something quietly devastating about how completely she had built a life that did not depend on being found.

Robert has raised a theory that deserves better treatment than a first draft of this paper gave it: that Ann herself followed Mary to Utica when the Children’s Law sent her daughter to the House of the Good Shepherd, and stayed close by — watching over her as best a penniless, unmarried woman could — until the day the orphan train took Mary away for good. That is not idle speculation. It may be the best explanation this paper has for a fact that has been sitting in the record all along, unexplained: of everywhere in New York State Ann could have rebuilt a life, she settled in Utica — the exact city her daughter

had been taken to — and never left it again until she died. The city directories that document her there only begin in 1889, but a directory only lists residents settled enough to be worth billing or canvassing; a servant or laundress moving between rooming houses in the early 1880s could easily go unlisted for years before finally appearing in print. Nothing in the record rules out Ann having arrived in Utica the same year Mary did, years before 1889. If that is what happened, it reframes the whole shape of Ann's later life: not a woman who simply ended up in Utica, but a mother who followed her daughter there and then spent the rest of her days within a few miles of the place she lost her.

Johanna Mary of Columbia, Illinois

From the House of the Good Shepherd, Mary's trail crosses 900 miles west to the German Catholic farming country of Monroe County, Illinois — and there, family memory and the paper record finally meet. In 2026 we found the adoption stated in print, in a county biographical volume published when Mary was seventeen:

"[John A. Pfeffer and his wife] also gave homes to two adopted children: Elizabeth Smith... and Johanna Mary, who is still living with them."

PORTRAIT AND BIOGRAPHICAL RECORD OF RANDOLPH, JACKSON, PERRY AND
MONROE COUNTIES, ILLINOIS, 1894

John A. Pfeffer (1844–1908), a general merchant of Columbia, and his wife **Johanna K. (Funk) Pfeffer** (1845–1915) raised fourteen children of their own — and still took in two more who had none. They were Roman Catholic, the son of a Bavarian immigrant; a devout, prosperous, crowded household. The 1900 census finds Mary there under the name the family gave her: *"Jennie Pfeffer, 24, adopted daughter, born Feb. 1876, New York."* And that solves a small puzzle that had run through her later records — why she sometimes appears as "Johanna M." or "Marietta J.": her adoptive parents named her *Johanna Mary*, after her new mother. The poorhouse baby from Rome, New York, grew up as a merchant's daughter named for the woman who chose her.

When she married, she did it under her legal birth name: on her 1904 Monroe County record she is *Marietta Blackwell*, age 27, bride of **Jacob Brand**, a Columbia contractor, son of

Joseph Brand of Baden — a Union veteran who had served in the 1st U.S. Reserve Corps Missouri Infantry in 1861. But when St. Louis newspapers printed her death notice decades later, they called her “*Marietta Brand (nee Pfeffer)*” — because to everyone who knew her, the Pfeffers were her family. Both names were true. And the truest record of all is in the ground at Immaculate Conception Catholic Cemetery in Columbia: Marietta and Jacob lie in row six — **directly behind John A. and Johanna Pfeffer in row five**. She was buried, by choice, at her adoptive parents’ backs.

Her life

Marietta and Jacob began their married life in Columbia. The 1910 census finds them there with a small son — **David**, born about 1906, who would grow up to be Grandma Bernadine’s father. Two more children followed: **Marietta** (born about 1911; her married name appears as *Rohlfing* on her father’s 1942 death certificate, where she signed as his informant) and **Vern Harry** (“Laverne,” born about 1919). By 1920 the family had crossed the river to St. Louis, settling on the city’s south side, where Jacob worked as a contractor.

She lived the rest of her life there. On the night of November 1, 1938, at St. Louis City Hospital, Marietta died of a cerebral embolism at age 61. Her death certificate — the official, final account of her life — contains two lines that carry the whole weight of her story:

MISSOURI CERTIFICATE OF DEATH · ST. LOUIS		No. 37226 · Nov. 1, 1938
NAME	<i>Maryetta Brand · wife of Jacob Brand</i>	
BORN	<i>February 2, 1877 · New York</i>	
NAME OF FATHER	Unknown	
MAIDEN NAME OF MOTHER	Unknown	
BURIAL	<i>November 5, 1938 · Columbia, Illinois</i>	

Even at the end, no one at her bedside could name her parents. For eighty-eight years, “Unknown” was the last word on where she came from. It isn’t anymore.

What became of Ann

The first edition ended Ann’s story where the poorhouse registers ended it. We can now follow her the rest of the way. After losing Mary to the Children’s Law, Ann did what she had always done: she worked. The Utica city directories of 1889–1891 list “*Anna Blackwell, laundress,*” living in a rear tenement at 55 Charlotte Street — a single Irish washerwoman, keeping herself, asking nothing of anyone.

By 1900 she had found a better place. The census that year records the household of David E. Owens — a young Utica fireman — and his wife **Lucy**, at 305 Sunset Avenue in West Utica. Living with them:

1900 UNITED STATES CENSUS · 305 SUNSET AVE., UTICA WARD 11		Owens household
NAME	<i>Annie Blackwell · Servant · single</i>	
BORN	<i>June 1854 · Ireland · parents born Ireland</i>	
IMMIGRATED	1880	
MOTHER OF HOW MANY CHILDREN	0	

Read those last two lines knowing what we know. Ann told the census taker she had arrived in 1880 and had never borne a child. Neither was true — in June 1880 she was in the Rome poorhouse beside her three-year-old daughter. This was the story she told the household she lived in, and probably everyone in her later life: a respectable servant’s biography with the poorhouse and the babies cut out. She carried Mary as a secret, and she carried her alone.

A word of caution about that census label, because it is the only place any record calls Ann a servant. “Servant” is the enumerator’s word — in 1900 it was virtually the only box available for a non-relative woman who kept house under someone else’s roof, and it cannot tell us whether Ann drew wages or was simply given a room and a place at the table in exchange for the work of her hands. What the records do show is that Lucy’s house had a habit of taking people in. She kept her first husband’s mother under that roof for twenty-four years, until the old woman died at 305 Sunset in 1901; a stepdaughter’s

wedding reception filled the same parlor in 1908. And in no other record we have found do the Owens keep a servant at all — this was a fireman's household, not a grand one. Whether Ann was staff, or a boarder who helped, or an aging woman sheltered partly out of kindness — or whether it began as one and became the other — the paper trail cannot say, and the reader is free to weigh it. What is beyond doubt is only this: she lived there, she worked, and the connection held.

In March 1905, too feeble to work any longer, Ann was admitted to the county almshouse one last time. On the line for *relatives or friends*, the keeper wrote the only name Ann had to give: **"Mrs. David Owens, 305 Sunset Ave., Utica"** — Lucy, the woman of the house on Sunset Avenue. Not kin, but the closest thing to family she had — and the form's own word for it, *friends*, may be the most honest word in all her records.



The women's day room of the Oneida County Almshouse, Rome, N.Y., photographed in 1900 — the ward Ann knew, five years before her final admission. (Harvard Art Museums / Fogg Museum collection.)

Ann died in the almshouse at 7 o'clock on the morning of October 31, 1905 — New York death certificate no. 46049, “a complication of diseases.” She was about 55, or 59, depending which of her own accounts you believe. An almshouse death in 1905 ordinarily meant one thing: an anonymous numbered stake in the county plot. Instead, the Rome Daily Sentinel printed eleven words that change how her story ends:

“The remains were taken to Utica, where she formerly resided, for interment.”

ROME DAILY SENTINEL, OCTOBER 31, 1905

Someone claimed her. Someone paid to bring her body thirteen miles home to Utica and bury her there — almost certainly the Owens household, the “friends” on her admission form, and most likely in consecrated Catholic ground. The woman who told the poorhouse in 1876 that she had *no relatives*, who was recorded arriving alone at fifteen, did not go to a pauper’s grave. At the very end, she belonged to somebody.

The girl on the ship

Ann told the almshouse in 1905 that she had been in the United States “about 40 years” — an emigration around 1865. In August 2026 we went looking for the ship. In the Castle Garden-era passenger lists for the Port of New York, across every arrival from 1861 to 1869, every port and every spelling, exactly **one** matching passenger appears:

PASSENGER MANIFEST · SHIP SCOTLAND · LIVERPOOL TO NEW YORK arr. May 28, 1866

NAME *Ann Blackwell*

AGE 15

OCCUPATION *Spinster*

TRAVELING WITH **No one — alone in steerage**

The arithmetic is almost uncanny: May 1866 to March 1905 is thirty-eight years and ten months — “about 40 years” on the nose. Age fifteen puts her birth at about 1851, the

midpoint of every age she ever gave. On the manifest she stands wedged between a big Irish family and a column of single laborers — a teenage girl alone on a steerage deck, three weeks out of Liverpool, which was the standard route out of Ireland (an unrecorded ferry from Dublin or Drogheda, then a Liverpool packet to New York).

One honest caveat belongs in the record: the manifest's nationality column marks her "English" — but the same clerk's ditto marks make an Englishman of "Bryan Hart" two lines below her, a name about as English as a shamrock. Liverpool clerks were careless with that column, and every American record of Ann's life — every census, both almshouse forms, her own statements about her parents — says Ireland. We hold this record as her *probable* arrival, and it is attached to her profile as such. If it is her, then the whole shape of her life is visible in one glance: she crossed the ocean alone at fifteen, and she was buried by friends at fifty-nine. Nobody carried her at the start. Somebody did at the end.

The road back to Ireland

Where in Ireland? We do not know yet — but for the first time, the question has edges. The surname Blackwell turns out to be genuinely *rare* in Ireland: the 1901 census of the whole island counted just 152 people bearing it. And though the name is English in origin, the Irish Blackwells were **majority Catholic** — 92 of the 152 — which fits Ann exactly. Griffith's Valuation, the great property survey taken across Ireland in the very years of Ann's childhood, shows only about 57 Blackwell households in the entire country, and they bunch into three clusters:

Before guessing, it helps to say exactly what any candidate parish must account for. Ann was born somewhere around 1846–1854 (most likely about 1851), to parents who were both Irish-born. She was Catholic. She left as a girl of about fifteen, alone, through Liverpool, in 1866 — the year after the American Civil War ended and the emigrant ships filled again. And she carried a rare English-origin surname that her family had held onto through the Famine. With those constraints, here are our best guesses — ranked, and offered as guesses, nothing more:

First guess: County Louth — the parish of Dunleer. The densest Blackwell cluster in all of Ireland sat in the mid-Louth countryside: fourteen households, seven of them in

Dunleer parish alone, still on the land in 1854 — meaning they survived the Famine in place, right in Ann’s birth window. This was overwhelmingly Catholic small-farm country, so those Blackwells were almost certainly Catholic like Ann. And Louth’s emigrants characteristically left exactly the way Ann did: the ferry from Drogheda or Dublin, then a Liverpool packet — the *Scotland’s* route precisely. Best of all for us, Dunleer’s Catholic baptism register survives from October 1847, squarely covering the years Ann would have been carried to the font. If we had to put a single pin in the map of Ireland, it goes in Dunleer.

Second guess: County Limerick. Sixteen households — the largest county total — centered on the Cappamore–Murroe district in the east of the county, with a few families in Limerick city’s parishes. Rural east-Limerick Blackwells would very likely have been Catholic, and Munster fed the post-Famine emigrant stream heavily. It ranks second only because the routes from Limerick ran more often through Queenstown than Liverpool.

Third guess — and the strangest: County Clare. Ten households in the north of the county, around Ennistymon and Kilshanny — plus the one thing no other county has: a documented, centuries-old *Catholic* Blackwell family of Ennis, a prosperous line with, of all things, **clergy connections**. We note that with care rather than excitement: it proves nothing about our Ann, and many Clare registers begin too late to hold her baptism. But it is striking that the one place in Ireland with a known Catholic Blackwell tradition tied to the clergy is also a fair match for Grandma Bernadine’s strangest, least explicable detail — the whispered rumor that Marietta’s people “*were possibly clergy in Ireland.*” If Ann’s trail ever runs to Clare, that old whisper will deserve a second listen.

Three counties, a dozen parishes, and surviving baptism registers: that is no longer a haystack. That is a search plan.

Five generations from the poorhouse door

THE LINE OF DESCENT

- **Ann Blackwell** (abt. 1846–51, Ireland – Oct. 31, 1905, Rome, N.Y.)

Crossed alone at fifteen; house servant, laundress, mother; buried in Utica by the friends who took her in

- **Mary “Marietta” Blackwell Brand** (1877, Rome, N.Y. – 1938, St. Louis)
Born in the poorhouse; raised as Johanna Mary by the Pfeffers of Columbia, Ill.; married Jacob Brand, 1904
- **David Brand** (abt. 1906, Columbia, Ill. –)
Her firstborn; later of Monrovia, California
- **Bernadine (Brand) Babcock** (1924, St. Louis – 2022, Portland, Ore.)
Who kept the story alive and told it to her grandson
- **Robert Babcock & family**
Who went looking — and found them both

It is worth pausing on what this line survived. An immigrant girl who crossed an ocean alone at fifteen. A daughter born in a poorhouse, separated from her mother by an act of the legislature, carried west and raised by strangers who became family. Within two generations, their descendants were homeowners, contractors, radio operators, servicemen. Grandma Bernadine was Marietta’s granddaughter — she was fourteen when Marietta died, old enough to have known her, and the story she passed down was not folklore. It was memory. Nearly every word of it has now been proved on paper.

The leads we are following

This is not a cold case. Every lead below is open, and several are already in motion. They are listed in the order we expect them to pay off.

In New York:

1. *Ann’s death certificate, no. 46049.* Filed at Rome in October 1905 and orderable from the Rome city clerk, it has printed lines for her father’s name and her mother’s maiden name. If the almshouse gave the registrar what Ann had told them, this single sheet of paper could name her parents — and parents’ names, run against the parish registers of our

three candidate counties, are exactly what cracks Irish research open. This is the most important document left on earth for this family, and it is the first thing we are pursuing.

2. *Her grave in Utica.* The friends who claimed her body in 1905 buried her in Utica, almost certainly in Catholic ground — St. Agnes Cemetery is the strongest candidate. The cemetery's interment book for November 1905 would confirm it, and if the Owens family bought her a stone, stones of that era sometimes name a county in Ireland. Nobody has looked yet.

3. *Mary's baptism at St. Peter's, Rome.* Ann was Catholic, and St. Peter's was Rome's old Irish parish — records back to 1837, "most of the early parishioners of Irish descent." A February 1877 baptism for Mary is very likely in its register, and Irish priests of that era sometimes recorded a mother's home parish in the margin. The same parish's funeral register may also hold Ann's November 1905 burial. The records now rest with St. Mary's/St. Peter's parish and the Diocese of Syracuse archives.

4. *The unindexed almshouse books.* Our correspondence with the New York State Archives (September 2026) confirmed that the inmate-census series our two Ann forms came from has *no name index* — it is arranged only by county, facility, and year. That means forms the databases never surfaced may still lie in the Oneida County reels: a readmission for Ann between 1877 and 1882, or a form for little Mary herself. We are paging through those years image by image.

5. *Mary's placement file.* The House of the Good Shepherd still operates in Utica today, and its 1880s placement ledgers — if they survive — would document how a Rome poorhouse toddler traveled 900 miles to a German Catholic merchant's house in Illinois. Monroe County, Illinois may hold the other end of that paper trail: a guardianship or adoption record for the Pfeffers, whose courthouse we have already written to.

6. *The two placing agencies.* The New York Foundling Hospital's own historical records are held today at NYU's Special Collections and by the Sisters of Charity of New York; the New York Juvenile Asylum's surviving ledgers are held privately by a researcher who maintains a partial name index online (which we have already checked for "Blackwell," with an honest negative). A direct research request to either archive, naming Mary's exact age and the mid-1880s window, is the most promising untried step toward confirming exactly how she reached Illinois — and possibly toward finding the brother Aunt Sandi remembers.

In Ireland:

7. *The Catholic parish registers themselves.* The National Library of Ireland has photographed virtually every surviving Catholic register in the country, free to read online, and FamilySearch has indexed them by name. We are searching for the baptism of an Ann (or Anne, Anna, or Nancy) Blackwell — also spelled Blackwall and easily confused with Blackall — between 1844 and 1856, starting in Dunleer and its neighbor parishes, then Limerick, then Clare. Dunleer is a small rural parish; even reading it page by page is only a few hours' work, and we intend to do exactly that.

8. *The 1901 Irish census.* Ireland's censuses recorded religion, and the returns are free online. Mapping which Blackwell households in 1901 were Catholic will confirm which of our three clusters were Ann's kind of Blackwells — and may reveal cousins who stayed when she sailed.

If even two of these pieces fall together — a parent's name from the death certificate, a matching baptism in a parish register — we will know the very townland this family walked out of. And then someone in this family can stand on that ground.

Sources

1. 1880 U.S. Federal Census, Rome, Oneida County, N.Y., Oneida County Poorhouse: Mary Blackwell, age 3, and Ann Blackwell, age 32, same dwelling and page. NARA T9, roll 903, E.D. 112, p. 61B, dw. 90.
2. Record of Inmates, Oneida County Poor House: Ann Blackwell, admitted Sept. 30, 1876. Census of Inmates in Almshouses and Poorhouses, 1875–1921. N.Y. State Archives, Series A1978, reel A1978:147, record 446.
3. Record of Inmates, Oneida County Almshouse: Anna Blackwell, admitted Mar. 16, 1905. N.Y. State Archives, Series A1978, reel A1978:150, record 4115.
4. Passenger manifest, ship *Scotland*, Liverpool to New York, arrived May 28, 1866: Ann Blackwell, 15. NARA M237, roll 266; N.Y. Passenger Lists 1820–1957.
5. 1900 U.S. Federal Census, Utica Ward 11, Oneida Co., N.Y.: household of David E. Owens, 305 Sunset Ave., incl. Annie Blackwell, servant. Also 1900 census, Columbia, Monroe Co., Ill.: household of John A. Pfeffer, incl. "Jennie Pfeffer, adopted daughter."
6. Utica city directories, 1889–1891: Anna Blackwell, laundress, rear 55 Charlotte St.

7. New York State death index: Anna Blackwell, Rome, Oct. 31, 1905, certificate no. 46049. Death notices, Rome Daily Sentinel, Oct. 31, 1905, and Utica Daily Press, Nov. 1, 1905.
8. *Portrait and Biographical Record of Randolph, Jackson, Perry and Monroe Counties, Illinois* (1894), biography of John A. Pfeffer, naming adopted daughter “Johanna Mary.”
9. Illinois County Marriage Records: Marietta Blackwell and Jacob Brand, Monroe County, 1904. U.S. Federal Censuses 1910, 1920, 1930, Jacob and Marietta Brand household.
10. Missouri Certificate of Death no. 37226, Maryetta Brand, Nov. 1, 1938, St. Louis. *Missouri State Archives*, digitized certificate 1938_00037233. Death notices, St. Louis newspapers, Nov. 4, 1938; Belleville (Ill.) Daily Advocate, Nov. 16, 1938.
11. Immaculate Conception Catholic Cemetery, Columbia, Ill., parish lot index: Brand graves row 6, Pfeffer graves row 5.
12. N.Y. Children’s Law of 1875 (ch. 173); N.Y. State Board of Charities annual reports on Oneida County practice. House of the Good Shepherd, Utica, institutional history.
13. Griffith’s Valuation of Ireland (1847–1864), Blackwell households by county; 1901 Census of Ireland surname and religion tabulations.
14. Photograph, women’s day room, Oneida County Almshouse, 1900. *Harvard Art Museums / Fogg Museum*.
15. U.S. Social Security Applications and Claims Index: claim of Vern Harry Brand naming mother “Mary Blackwel.”
16. Oral history of Bernadine (Brand) Babcock, as told to Robert Babcock.

All records cited are attached to the corresponding people in the Robert Babcock Family Tree on Ancestry, where the original document images can be viewed.

*For Ann, who crossed alone and was carried home by friends —
and for Bernadine, who never let us forget.*